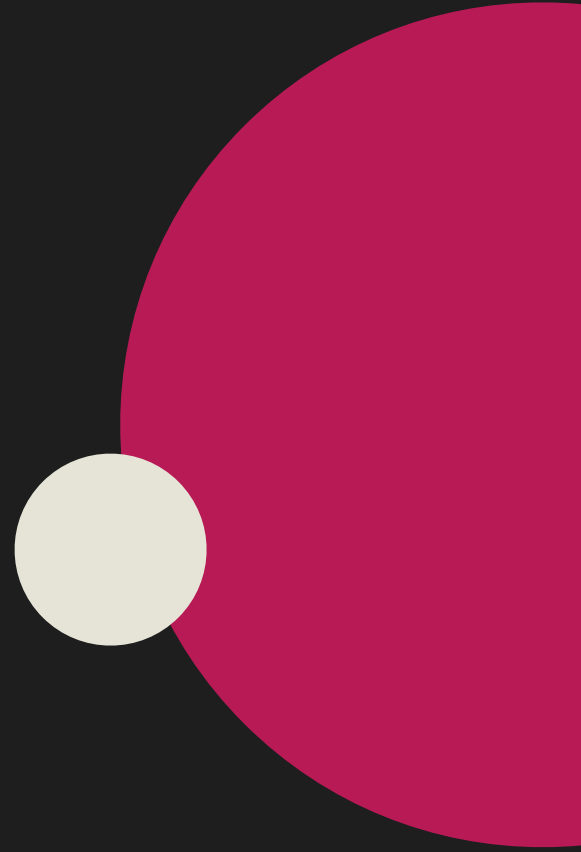


HIERO COMMUNITY DAY — BERLIN — 07.07.2026

# Why does community matter?

Sophie Bulloch



# OSS licence is not a community

open source promises: anyone may **view** · **modify** · **distribute**. that's all it promises.



Someone still has to want and build the community

# Tragedy of the commons —> tiny community?

“

the code is free to view, modify  
and distribute...

...so why would I do any work?  
I can wait for others to improve  
it.

”

everyone waits for everyone else



under-investment in the shared code



dangerous dependence on 1–2 maintainers,  
with no succession plan

# Consequences of under-investment: xz utils

- one maintainer, alone and unpaid, carrying a library the world uses
- two years of pressure to grant others permissions
- a backdoor created by a new permission holder — caught by luck, weeks before it reached most of the world's servers

*A baffling example of a package used by millions was maintained by one overworked volunteer*

# The xz conditions are the baseline

60%

not paid for their work

~60%

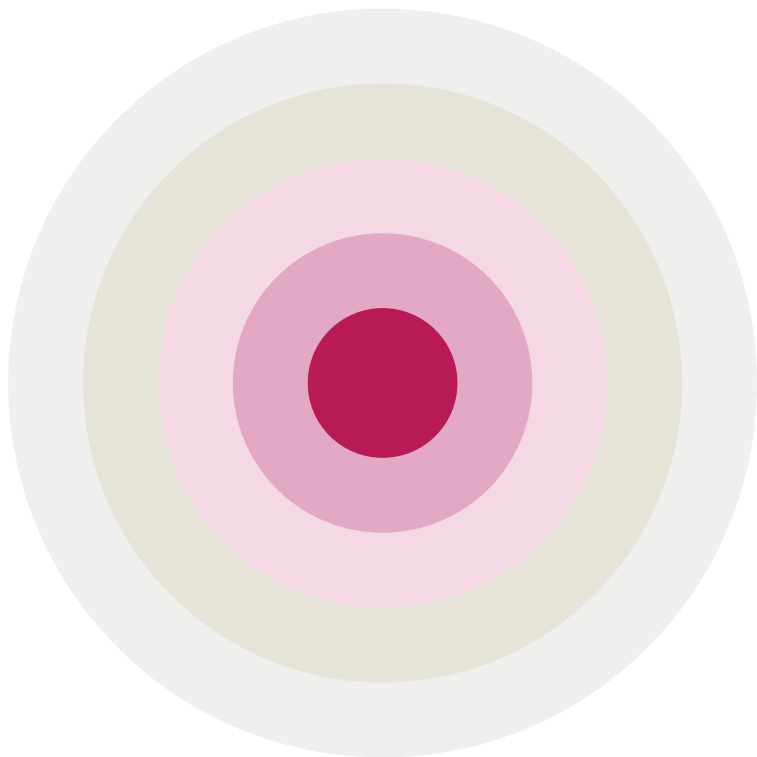
have quit or considered  
quitting

61%

maintain completely alone

design conflict? → **opportunities for everyone, do not harm maintainers**

# Benefit of OSS Communities: 1. Sustainability



-  **users** the widest ring — everyone the code serves
-  **bug reporters** the first step inward
-  **contributors** a patch, a doc fix, an answer
-  **committers** trusted, regular, closer to the core
-  **maintainers** the small core carrying the load

Contributors start on the edges and move inwards

# Must OSS Communities Be Small?



## edges → core

you learn a craft by participating at the edge and moving inward

lave & wenger 1991



## contributors out-learn free-riders

firms that contribute capture more value than firms that only consume

nagle 2018



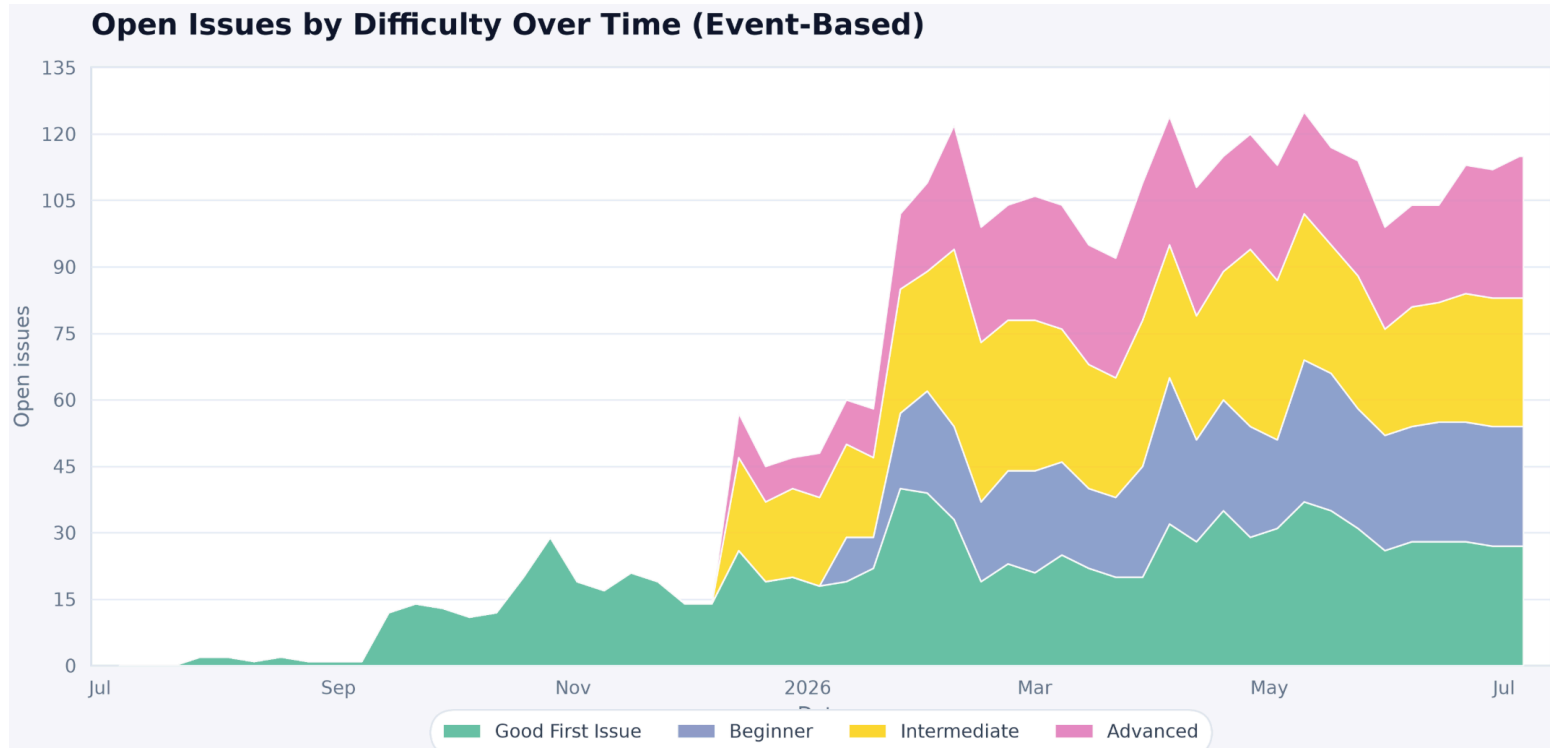
## practice compounds

release habits, testing tricks, “how we solved pagination” — spread to every project at once

no docs can substitute

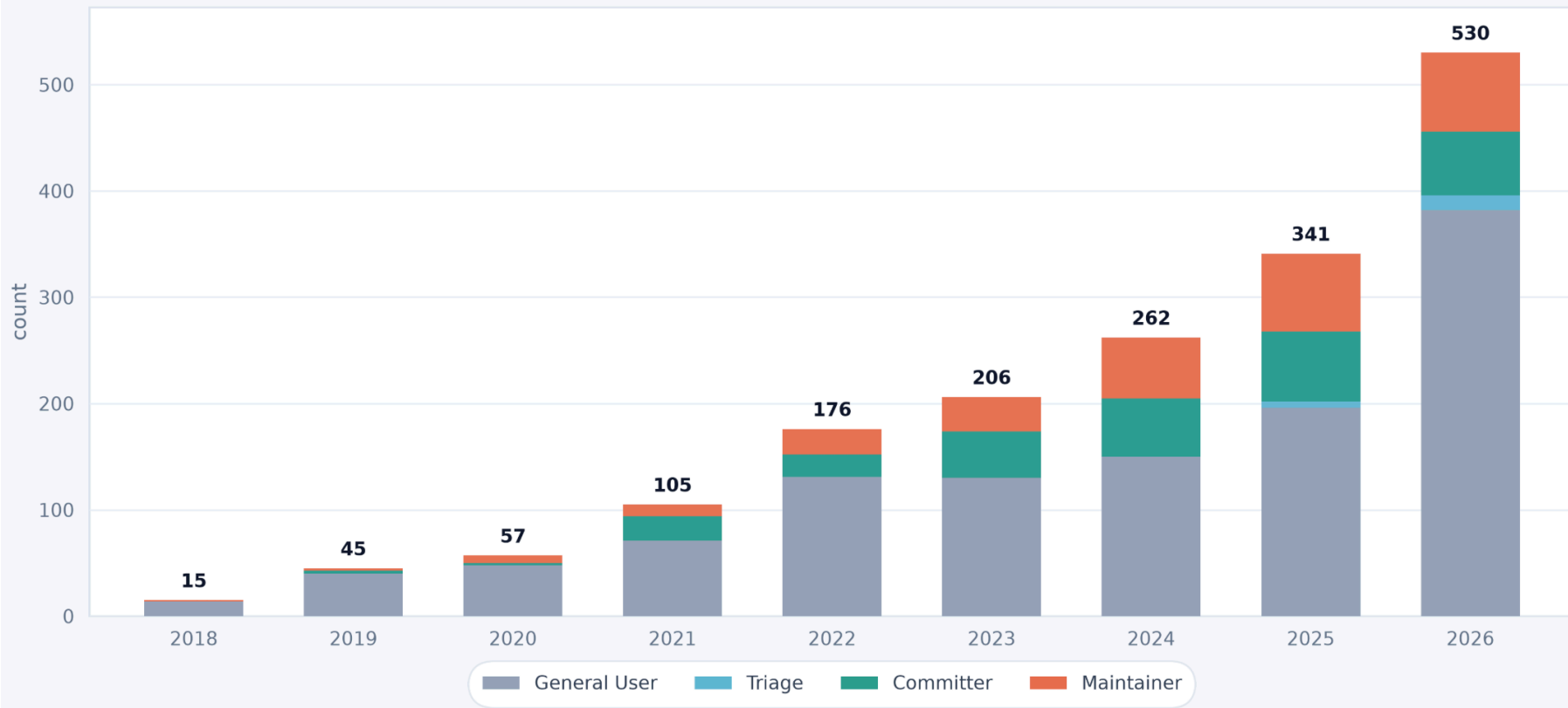
Not if you give people the chance to (safely) learn

# Members progress in earned responsibilities





## Maintainer Pipeline: Unique Active Contributors by Role - PR & Issue Activity (Yearly)



# Benefit of OSS Communities: 2. Shared Knowledge



projects interlinked



feedback from users  
and similar projects



support when stuck



bug reports answered



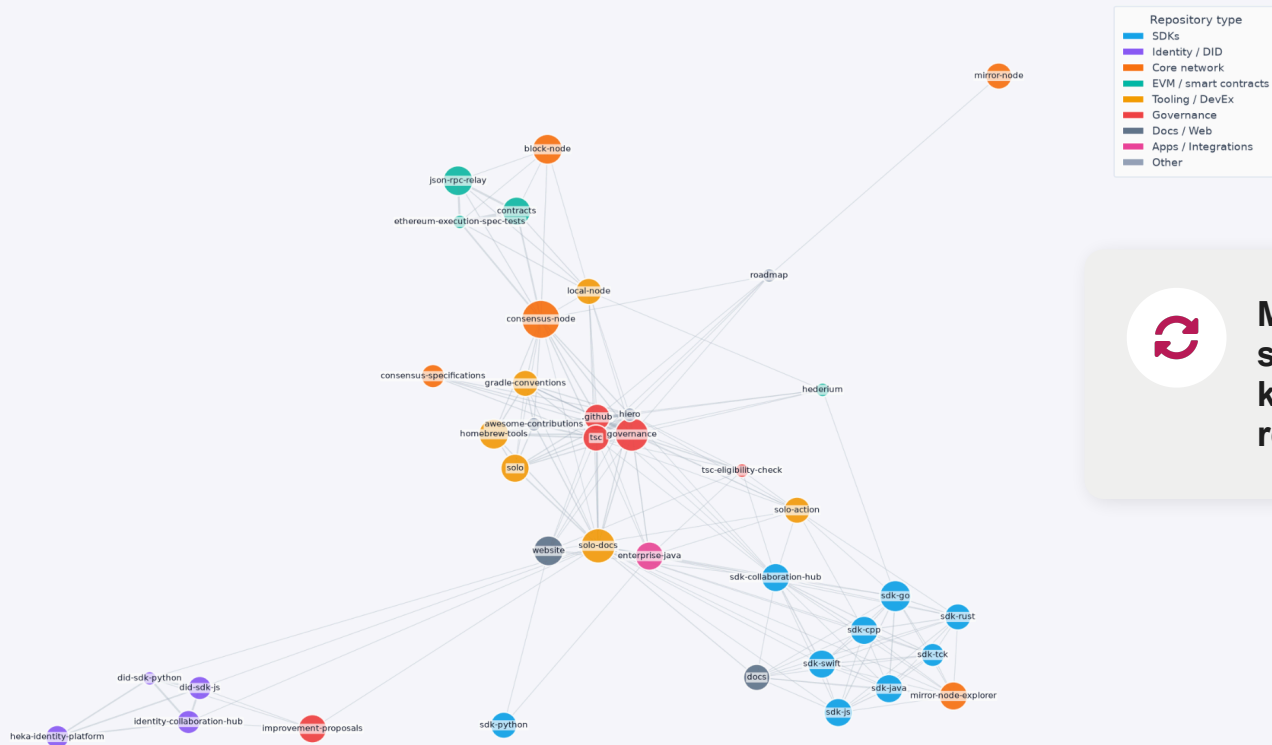
Reviews or feedback  
in days or weeks



real discussion on  
issues

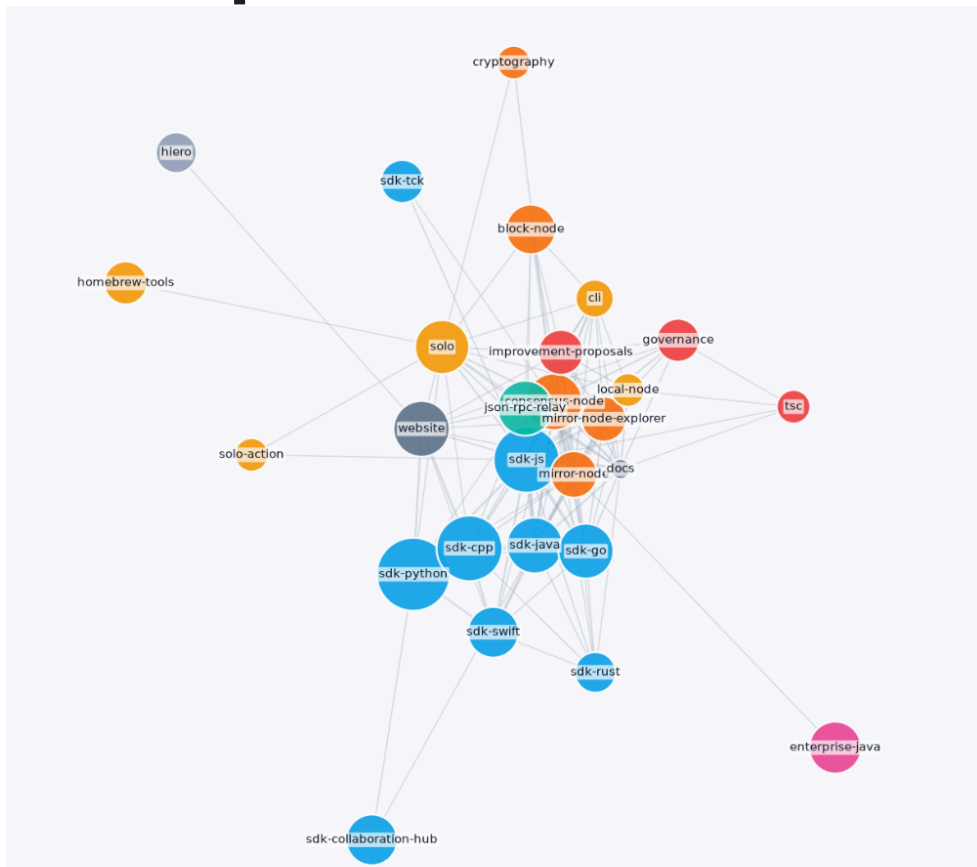
# Example: Shared Maintainer Knowledge

hierio-ledger — maintainers network (repos linked by shared maintainers)



**Maintainers already share their knowledge across repositories**

# Example: Shared Contributor Knowledge



The education burden  
is not on any single  
repository - one's  
effort benefits all

# Benefit of OSS Communities: 3. Complementary, Shared Infrastructure



**Game developers**

Want to focus on building a game!

**B  
U  
T**



mirror node pagination



analytics layer



account management

... leading to buggy code with less time game developing

Software development is **3.5×** cheaper with OSS

# Example at Hiero: SDKs leading to AI +



each complement is a map for the one after it – and reveals what to build next

mirror node parser (rust)

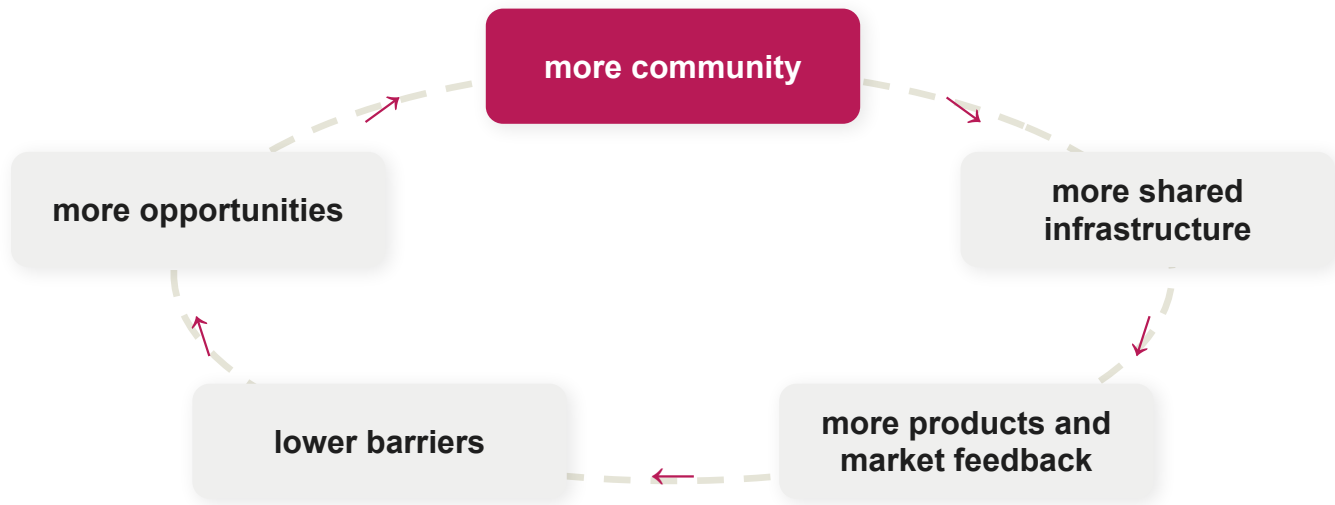
C# SDK

maintainer automations

**96%** of OSS value comes  
from **5%** of developers

OSS development thrives when communities build shared infrastructure on purpose.

# The flywheel of OSS Communities



# The Need for Hiero Hackers

Maintainers have a lot on their plate.

What if we can grow the community without adding more tasks to maintainers?



## real ownership

create and maintain code you  
care about



## feedback, not gates

maintainers advise — never  
block.



## shared infrastructure

Projects thrive from each  
other's success



TASKS FOR THIS MONTH

# Community is the production system.



label one issue by difficulty



create an issue in a new project



answer one newcomer's first question



seed a shared infrastructure library in hiero hackers

*the more we build together, the better we build*